GitHub stars it has is not sufficient (this is purely a popularity indicator). You need to invest the time to look at the release cadence (you should be able to accommodate the pace), how many contributors (ideally, multiple, from different places) and users (ideally, in different industry verticals) it has, the documentation available, how many issues and pull or merge requests there are (and how quickly they get addressed), and a strategy for support (i.e., in-house or community-based), as support is key to enterprise usage.

- One of the increasingly more relevant and requested features that helps you more efficiently use your tool of choice is correlation (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qVITI34ZFuk). Make sure you check what kind of correlation (time-based, exemplars, etc.; see also chapter 11) is available and how much manual work is required to go from one signal type to another, assuming the tool you're evaluating, indeed, supports more than one signal type, which is the basis for correlation to work.

TIP Given the very nature of the frontends and all-in-ones, being the visible part end users interact with, make sure you bring all stakeholders on board. Selecting a tool purely based on a price tag or because of how polished it is may turn out to be challenging.

Now, that was a lot of new information! I hope you can use it to your advantage when selecting tooling in this space. It's a fast-moving and exciting space, so it makes sense to revisit your choices on a regular basis.

Summary

- Frontends allow you to interact with the observability datasets stored in backends.
- You use a frontend to find answers to your (ad hoc) questions in various graphical and textual manners.
- There are many open source frontends (Grafana, Kibana, Metabase, etc.) available, and when you build your own in-house observability solution, consider these rather than building something from scratch.
- All-in-ones are an excellent choice if you manage to avoid too much vendor lock-in; they allow you to outsource most of the operational burden and typically provide you with a range of functionality, for a premium.
- What used to be APM is now, by and large, rebranded as distributed tracing.
- Selecting tools in this space can be tricky, but make sure you understand costs associated with it well and have a clear idea of the value you want to deliver (and to whom).
- Picking open source tooling is a great way to be interoperable and vendor agnostic; however, make sure you understand the dynamics of the open source project and have a clear strategy for getting support.